

Coaching vs Mentoring vs Managing

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Coaching vs Mentoring vs Managing

A clear comparison guide explaining the difference between coaching, mentoring, and managing — with practical examples, a decision guide, and tips for blending all three.

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WHY THIS DISTINCTION MATTERS

Most people default to one mode regardless of what the moment actually calls for — usually managing, because it feels fastest under pressure. The strongest leaders can recognise which mode a situation needs and move between all three deliberately, rather than relying on the one they're most comfortable with.

Three-Way Comparison

	Coaching	Mentoring	Managing
Primary Purpose	Unlock the person's own thinking to help them find their own answer.	Share experience and perspective from someone who's navigated a similar path.	Direct and organise work to deliver a specific outcome.
Who Holds the Answers	The person being coached — the coach rarely gives advice.	The mentor, drawn from their own lived experience.	The manager, based on organisational priorities and standards.
Time Horizon	Often short-term and issue- or goal-specific.	Long-term, usually career- or development-oriented.	Immediate — task- and deadline-driven.
Typical Approach	Open questions, active listening, minimal advice-giving.	Storytelling, advice, and lessons learned from experience.	Instructions, direction, and clear performance expectations.
Relationship Dynamic	Peer-like and non-hierarchical, even when a manager is coaching.	Experienced-to-less-experienced, but not a reporting line.	Hierarchical, with formal authority and accountability.
Best Used When	The person has the capability but needs to find their own way forward.	The person needs perspective from someone who has faced something similar.	The task requires direction, coordination, or a fixed deadline.

Practical Examples

The same situation, handled through each of the three approaches. Notice how the words themselves signal which mode is in play.

A team member says they're unsure whether to apply for a stretch role.

COACHING	<i>"What would make this role exciting to you? What's holding you back from applying? What would you need to feel ready?"</i>
MENTORING	<i>"When I was weighing a similar move, here's what mattered most for me... In my experience, the biggest factor was X, not Y."</i>
MANAGING	<i>"Here's what the role requires, here's the application deadline, and here's my honest view on your current readiness."</i>

A team member has missed the same deadline twice in a row.

COACHING	<i>"What's getting in the way of hitting this deadline? What would need to change for it to be different next time?"</i>
MENTORING	<i>"I used to struggle with exactly this. What worked for me was breaking the deliverable down earlier — want me to show you how?"</i>
MANAGING	<i>"This deadline is not optional. I need a revised plan by end of day, and I'll be checking in daily until it's back on track."</i>

Decision Guide

Use this as a quick reference when you're not sure which mode a situation calls for.

If the situation is...	Use this mode
The person has the skill but lacks confidence or clarity on next steps.	Coaching
The person is early in their career and wants perspective from someone further along.	Mentoring
The task has a hard deadline and no real room for exploration.	Managing
The person is stuck and needs space to think it through themselves.	Coaching
The person is facing a decision you've personally navigated before.	Mentoring
Performance standards aren't being met and must be corrected directly.	Managing
The person wants long-term career or professional development guidance.	Mentoring
A genuine crisis requires immediate, unambiguous action.	Managing

ONE SITUATION, MULTIPLE MODES

These rules describe a single moment, not a fixed relationship. The same person might need coaching on Monday, mentoring on Wednesday, and clear direction on Friday — the mode should follow the situation, not a label you've assigned to that relationship permanently.

Blending Approaches

Few real conversations are purely one mode. These are the practical adjustments that help you move between all three without the shift feeling jarring to the other person.

01 Name the mode you're in

Say it out loud, especially when switching within the same conversation: "Let me step out of manager mode for a second and just ask..."

02 Watch for defaulting to managing under time pressure

Urgency makes directing feel faster, even when coaching would build more capability for next time. Notice the trade-off you're making.

03 Don't mentor when coaching is what's needed

Sharing your own story can subtly imply there's one right answer. If the person needs to find their own path, hold the advice back.

04 Don't coach when someone actually wants direction

Endless open questions can feel evasive to someone who is genuinely asking, "Just tell me what to do." Read the moment, not just the relationship.

05 Revisit the mode as the conversation moves

A single conversation often needs all three — opening with coaching questions, moving to mentoring perspective, and closing with a managing decision on next steps.

THE UNDERLYING SKILL

Recognising which mode a moment calls for — and having the range to actually deliver it — is a more valuable leadership skill than being excellent at any single one of the three in isolation.